of the latter's sovereignty and territorial integrity, the US has been very careful to declare in advance that it would neither put boots on the ground nor countenance a direct military confrontation with Russian forces in Ukraine. It declined to permit Polish MIG aircraft to be flown from a US military base in Germany for use by Ukrainian pilots. In the case of Taiwan, the US has maintained a position of strategic ambiguity, which means that it may or may not intervene militarily in case China decides to attempt to reunify Taiwan with itself by force. This is despite the fact that the US has not contested Chinese sovereignty over Taiwan and maintains no formal diplomatic relations with the island. The US says its unwillingness to risk a direct confrontation with Russia is because the latter is a nuclear weapons state and there is danger of such a confrontation escalating into a nuclear war. But would not the same argument apply in the case of a US conflict with China over Taiwan, since China, too, is a nuclear weapons state?

If a swift Russian victory over Ukraine might have emboldened China to become more aggressive towards Taiwan and in the Indo-Pacific generally, the turn of events against Russia and its increasing international isolation are likely to make China more cautious. China would be particularly mindful of having to face the kind of economic and financial sanctions currently heaped on Russia. This may be the reason it has changed tack in suggesting that a crisis similar to Ukraine's may erupt in the Indo-Pacific should the US try to lead a containment ring around China. This is a defensive reaction, quite in contrast to the earlier dismissals of the Quad and the Indo-Pacific strategy by Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi. He had described the Quad as a 'headline grabbing idea' that 'would soon dissipate'. He had said the US Indo-Pacific strategy was like 'sea foam in the Indian or Pacific Ocean'. [3] There may be a tempering of Chinese ambitions in Asia for the time being, but this is unlikely to change China's long-term objective of establishing, in Asia, a hierarchical economic and security architecture with its own place at its apex. Russia will be a lesser ally than anticipated in supporting China's Asian ambitions, but it is unlikely that this will persuade China to downsize its 'China Dream'.

It is also likely that China will make certain tactical shifts in its policy